



Battle for Son Tay

In December 1883, at the town of Son Tay, Vietnamese and Chinese forces resisted the French takeover of Tonkin (northern Vietnam). Although ultimately victorious, the French suffered heavy casualties.

Assault on Tonkin

In 1883, France launched a sea and land offensive in Tonkin, the northern heartland of Vietnam, to force the Vietnamese imperial government to accept a French protectorate. Assisted by Chinese irregulars known as the Black Flags, as well as by Chinese regular troops, the Vietnamese inflicted heavy losses on the French Expeditionary Force. In 1885, however, China made peace with France at Tientsin, and although armed resistance continued in some parts of Tonkin, the Vietnamese government had no choice but to acknowledge French control.

French rule

The colonial system imposed by France did not even recognize the existence of “Vietnam.” Instead, French Indochina—established in 1887—was a union of Tonkin, Annam (central Vietnam), Cochin China, and Cambodia, with Laos added in 1893. Vietnam, as it had been prior to the French takeover, was split into three. Imposed in order to make the territory easier for the French to control, this division of Vietnam also had historic justifications. Cochin China had only been settled by Vietnamese peasants relatively recently and had not come under the rule of a Vietnamese emperor until the 19th century. Nonetheless, the Vietnamese people had a strong sense of national identity, and many were unhappy with these divisions.

Administration of Indochina was headed by a governor-general who reported to the Colonial Office in Paris. Meanwhile, traditional rulers retained their thrones, yet had little real power and were readily dismissed if the French found them insufficiently subservient. The Vietnamese emperor still had his court at Hue and his mandarins (high-level bureaucrats) exercised some authority in Annam, but even there the French ran the show.